

STAGE FIVE • THINKING, REASONING & MENTAL MODELS

FIRSTS

FAQ

Anticipated participant questions and suggested facilitator responses

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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Stage Five • Thinking, Reasoning & Mental Models

PURPOSE

These are the questions that come up most often across cohorts of Stage Five, with a suggested facilitator response for each. Use these as a starting point, not a rigid script.

Frequently Asked Questions

Q1. What if I can't think of a real problem to apply a framework to?

A: Look at something small and current — a scheduling conflict, a purchase decision, a disagreement with a friend. The frameworks in this stage work on genuinely minor decisions just as well as major ones; the practice matters more than the stakes.

Q2. Do I have to use a different real example for every single FIRST?

A: No — in fact, using the same real decision across several related FIRSTS (especially in Session 3) often works better, since you can see how different frameworks illuminate different aspects of the same problem.

Q3. What if my Cognitive Bias Audit doesn't turn up anything? I don't think I'm that biased.

A: That belief is itself one of the most well-documented biases there is — the assumption that your own reasoning is unusually objective. Try applying the audit to one specific recent decision rather than searching for bias in the abstract; it tends to surface more that way.

Q4. Is this stage more about business strategy, or does it apply to personal life too?

A: These frameworks originated in business and strategy contexts, but every exercise in this stage is designed to apply to personal, academic, or professional decisions equally. A decision matrix works as well for choosing an apartment as it does for choosing a vendor.

Q5. What if two frameworks seem to give me different answers for the same decision?

A: That's genuinely useful information, not a failure of either framework. Different tools highlight different aspects of a decision — FIRST H28 (Mental Model Combination) is specifically about working with that kind of tension rather than expecting one clean answer.

Q6. How do I know when I've found the real root cause versus just another symptom?

A: There's no perfect test, but a good sign is when the answer feels a little uncomfortable or surprising rather than convenient. If the “root cause” you've found conveniently avoids any responsibility on your part, it's worth digging one level further.